

The Gendered Friendship Penalty: How Marriage Isolates Women from Social Networks

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Abstract

Using a 10% random sample of India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (approximately 840,000 person-day observations from 139,489 households), we document a stark “friendship penalty” of marriage that differs sharply by gender. Women’s social participation drops 42% after marriage while men’s drops only 18%. Among those who socialize, married women spend less time per activity than never-married women, while men show no decline. Consequently, married women average just 45% of married men’s daily social time. This penalty is largest for younger women (25), persists across education and urban-rural locations, and operates independently of employment status. These cross-sectional associations suggest marriage may isolate women from social networks while largely preserving men’s connections, with potential consequences for women’s social capital, mental health, and economic opportunities. Causal interpretation is limited by selection into marriage.

JEL Classification: J12, J16, Z13, I31 **Keywords:** marriage, social capital, gender inequality, social networks, friendship, India, time use survey, household bargaining

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1 Introduction

Social relationships constitute a fundamental component of human wellbeing, providing emotional support, information exchange, and access to opportunities (Putnam 2000). Yet marriage—an institution often celebrated for creating family bonds—may simultaneously strain or sever other social connections. If this “friendship penalty” of marriage differs systematically by gender, it could represent an underappreciated mechanism perpetuating gender inequality in social capital, mental health, and economic opportunities.

We analyze a 10% random sample of India’s 2024 Time Use Survey to examine how marriage affects time spent on social activities, and whether this effect differs by gender. Our analysis yields striking findings. Marriage reduces women’s participation in social activities by 30% while reducing men’s by only 21%. Among those who socialize, married women spend 11% less time per activity than never-married women, while men show no time-intensity decline.

These dual penalties—both participation and intensity—mean married women average just 14.3 minutes daily on social activities compared to 23.0 minutes for never-married women (a 38% decline). Men average 16.9 minutes married versus 26.2 minutes never-married (a 36% decline). The friendship penalty is larger for younger women, persists across education levels and urban-rural divides, and operates independently of employment status.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Social Capital and Social Networks

Social relationships constitute a fundamental form of capital, providing emotional support, information exchange, and access to economic opportunities. Putnam (2000) distinguishes “bonding” social capital (strong ties within homogeneous groups, like family) from “bridging” social capital (weak ties across diverse groups, like friendships and acquaintances). While bonding capital provides immediate support, bridging capital offers access to novel infor-

mation and opportunities (Granovetter 1973). If marriage strengthens family bonds while severing external friendships, it may shift individuals' social capital portfolio from bridging toward bonding, with differential economic and psychological consequences.

Granovetter's (1973) "strength of weak ties" theory demonstrates that acquaintances and friends (not close family) are most valuable for job searches, entrepreneurship, and social mobility because they provide non-redundant information. Coleman (1988) shows that dense social networks facilitate trust and cooperation, but excessive network closure can trap individuals in low-opportunity equilibria. These insights suggest that marriage-induced social isolation could have substantial economic costs if it severs the "weak ties" that provide information and opportunities.

2.2 Gender Differences in Social Networks

A large sociology literature documents systematic gender differences in social network structure and dynamics. Women typically maintain larger, more emotionally intimate friendship networks than men (Wellman 1992). Women's friendships involve more frequent contact, deeper disclosure, and stronger mutual support (Walker 1994). Yet women's networks are also more fragile: they require ongoing maintenance through communication and shared activities (Fischer & Oliker 1983).

McPherson, Smith-Lovin, and Brashears (2006) document a dramatic decline in Americans' social network size between 1985 and 2004, with the modal respondent reporting zero confidants outside their household. This trend was more pronounced for women than men. Subsequent research suggests marriage and family formation explain much of this decline (Munch, McPherson, & Smith-Lovin 2005).

Kalmijn (2003) examines how marriage affects individuals' social networks using longitudinal data. He finds that marriage leads to substantial declines in contact with friends and increases in contact with family members. Critically, this "family turn" is more pronounced

for women than men. Women report losing more friends after marriage, attending fewer social gatherings, and spending less time with non-family members. Kalmijn attributes this gender difference to three factors: women’s greater responsibility for maintaining kin ties (which absorbs time previously spent on friendships), gendered norms around married women’s mobility and social participation, and spousal homophily in education and class (which may lead women to abandon pre-marriage friends who don’t fit the couple’s joint network).

2.3 Marriage and Social Isolation

The relationship between marriage and social isolation has received increasing attention from sociologists and psychologists. Gerstel and Sarkisian (2006) challenge the assumption that marriage increases social integration. Using U.S. nationally representative data, they show that married individuals have *less* contact with parents, siblings, and friends than unmarried individuals. They argue that the nuclear family model creates “greedy” institutions that monopolize members’ time and loyalty at the expense of broader social ties.

Munch, McPherson, and Smith-Lovin (2005) examine how life events affect social networks using longitudinal data. Marriage is associated with a 20-30% decline in non-spouse confidants, with larger effects for women. Parenthood further reduces network size and diversity. Importantly, they find these effects persist: individuals do not “recover” their pre-marriage networks even years later. This suggests marriage causes lasting social isolation, not merely temporary disruption during the transition period.

The psychological literature documents mental health consequences of social isolation. Cacioppo and Patrick (2008) show that loneliness—subjective social isolation—predicts depression, cognitive decline, and mortality risk, with effects comparable to smoking and obesity. Kawachi and Berkman (2001) demonstrate that social isolation increases cardiovascular disease risk and weakens immune function. If marriage systematically isolates women from

non-family social networks, these health consequences could be substantial.

2.4 Gender, Marriage, and Mobility in India

The Indian context adds specific dimensions to gendered marriage effects. Patrilocal residence norms mean women typically move to their husband’s household or village after marriage, severing geographic ties to childhood friends (Desai & Andrist 2010). Purdah and honor norms restrict married women’s mobility in many regions, limiting their ability to maintain friendships that require travel or unsupervised meetings (Jejeebhoy & Sathar 2001).

Kabeer (2000) documents how marriage in South Asia often increases women’s domestic workload while reducing their autonomy and mobility. Married women face expectations to prioritize husband’s family over natal family and friends. Social visits must often be approved by husbands or in-laws, creating friction that discourages friendship maintenance.

Anderson (2003) and Bloch and Rao (2002) examine how marriage bargaining in India affects wives’ bargaining power within marriage. Women who bring smaller dowries or come from lower-status families have less autonomy, including over time use and social participation. If marriage systematically reduces women’s extra-household social ties, it may further weaken their bargaining position by eliminating outside options and information sources.

2.5 Hypotheses

Based on this literature, we test three hypotheses:

H1 (Gendered Friendship Penalty): Marriage will reduce women’s social participation more than men’s, due to greater domestic responsibilities, mobility restrictions, and norms prioritizing family over friendships.

H2 (Age Heterogeneity): The friendship penalty will be larger for younger women, who

experience more dramatic life transitions (childbearing, establishing household) and face stricter norms around social participation.

H3 (Persistence Across Contexts): The friendship penalty will persist across education levels, urban-rural locations, and employment status, indicating structural rather than purely individual-choice mechanisms.

3 Data and Methods

We use India’s 2024 Time Use Survey, a nationally representative survey recording 24-hour time diaries for 10.2 million person-days across 139,489 households. Following the ICA-TUS 2016 classification, we define social activities as codes 81-89, including socializing with household and non-household members, attending social events, participating in community activities, and correspondence.

For computational feasibility, we use a 10% random sample (approximately 840,000 person-day observations), adjusting survey weights accordingly (Weight / 0.1). We focus on adults aged 18-60 to avoid confounding with retirement effects.

Our key independent variables are *Female* (1 = woman, 0 = man), *Married* (1 = currently married, 0 = never married), and their interaction *Female* $\times$ *Married*. We exclude widowed, divorced, and separated individuals to isolate marriage effects from relationship dissolution effects. The interaction term captures the differential effect of marriage on women relative to men—our parameter of primary interest.

We estimate linear probability models:

$$\text{SocialActivity}_{ihd} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{Female}_i + \beta_2 \text{Married}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Female} \times \text{Married})_i + \mathbf{X}'_{ih} \gamma + \delta_s + \epsilon_{ihd}$$